ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 252: Fundamentals of Radio, TV and Film Production

Plan, shoot and edit a short production with the equipment you actually have

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack is a production manual for students with limited equipment: a phone, a borrowed camera and free editing software. It covers formats and durations, scripting for radio and screen, shooting coverage, sound capture, editing workflow and delivery formats.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Write a production proposal with format, audience, duration and budget.
- Record clean sound and shoot usable coverage on limited equipment.
- Edit a short sequence with continuity and a coherent mix.
- Export and deliver in the required broadcast or online format.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Formats and scripts

Different media demand different scripts.

- Radio drama: sound-only storytelling; write for ears, not eyes.
- Radio magazine or news: timing, cue and actuality inserts.
- Television: visual continuity, presenter links and package structure.
- Short film: visual storytelling with economy; fewer locations, stronger scenes.
- Documentary: research, contributor access, ethics and release forms.
- Always write to a duration you can actually fill.

Production on limited equipment

Technique beats gear at student level.

- Lock exposure and focus manually where possible; autofocus hunts in low light.
- Record sound close to the source; a cheap lavalier beats a distant camera mic.
- Shoot coverage: wide, medium, close and cutaways for every scene.
- Observe the 180-degree rule and keep screen direction consistent.
- Use available light thoughtfully; bounce and diffuse before adding fixtures.
- Log every take with scene, shot and notes.

> **Sound first**
> Audiences forgive soft images but not unusable audio. Capture clean dialogue and wild track before you chase a prettier shot.

Post-production and delivery

Editing is where the story is actually built.

- Organise footage by scene and take before editing.
- Assemble a rough cut for story, then refine rhythm.
- Keep audio levels consistent; avoid clipping.
- Add music only where licensed or original.
- Colour-correct for consistency rather than spectacle.
- Export to the required codec, resolution and duration; check playback on a phone.

The production chain, end to end

Every production, from a thirty-second radio ident to a short film, runs the same chain: development, pre-production, production, post-production, distribution. The proportions change but the order does not, and skipping a stage costs more later than it would have cost then.

Pre-production is where the production is actually won. Script locked, locations confirmed with written permission, equipment tested, crew roles assigned, schedule written with travel time, and a shot list or running order prepared. A student crew that arrives without a shot list will shoot what is in front of them and discover in the edit that a reaction shot was never captured.

Post-production is where the material becomes a programme. Logging, assembly, rough cut, sound work, colour, titles and export. Export settings matter: a file that is too large to submit or too compressed to screen has failed the assignment at the last step.

Sound first, because it is hardest to fix

Audiences forgive soft images and abandon poor sound. On location, record dialogue close with a directional microphone whenever possible, monitor with headphones, and capture thirty seconds of room tone at every setup. Wind, traffic and generator hum are the three most common destroyers of amateur footage, and all three are solved by microphone placement and a little patience.

Radio production is sound design without a picture, which makes it the best training for film sound. Build a scene from three layers: speech, effects that establish place, and music or silence that carries emotion. Keep levels consistent and remember that a listener needs a moment to recognise a new location, so transitions need a bridge - a door, a crowd, a change of acoustic.

For television, observe the formats: the package with a presenter link, the studio interview with cutaways, the magazine item with a fixed duration. Formats constrain content, and a producer who ignores the format will have the item cut for them.

> **Test the kit before you leave**
> Batteries, cards, cables, adapters, a backup recorder and a charged phone. Equipment failure is the most common cause of a lost shoot day, and the most preventable.

Roles, safety and permissions

A small crew still needs defined roles: producer (schedule, permissions, budget), director (interpretation and performance), camera, sound, and a runner who also handles continuity. Where one person holds two roles, write down which hat is on for each part of the day, or decisions will be made twice and differently.

Permissions are part of production. Written consent to film on private property, consent from people who appear on camera, and caution about filming identifiable people in sensitive situations. Consent is not a formality: it protects the contributor and the production.

Safety on set is boring and non-negotiable: cables taped down, no one behind a reversing vehicle, lamps given space and kept away from fabric, and a first-aid point known to everyone. Never rig anything above head height without someone competent to check it.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 252

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 252 Fundamentals of Radio, Television and Film Production
- Electronic media designs, audio-visual production styles for radio, television, filmic rendition and documentary
- Use of media, equipment and studio environments emphasised

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 252 Fundamentals of Radio, TV and Film Production, 3 credits, second semester, 200 level
- THA 324 Techniques of Radio, TV and Film Directing and Production follows at 300 level
- THA 333 Jingle and Effects Design for Radio and Television also listed

What changed: The 2019 listing separates production fundamentals (252) from directing (324) and effects design (333).

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Production fundamentals remains the 200-level media core
- Expect a submitted production artefact, not only a written exam
- Confirm equipment booking rules and whether you may shoot on a phone

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Planning a two-minute radio package

You have three interviews, forty minutes of material and a two-minute slot.

1. Write the story in one sentence and decide the order: hook, context, evidence, close.
2. Select three actuality clips - the best eight seconds of each speaker, not the longest.
3. Record a link that sets the scene in one line.
4. Add two effects that establish place, and one pause before the final quote.
5. Lay the bed music under the link only, ducked to stay below speech.
6. Time it aloud; two minutes of radio is roughly 280-320 words plus actuality.
7. Export as a single mono file at broadcast level.

> **What to carry forward**
> Write for the ear and cut for the clock. The best clip is the shortest one that makes the point.

2. Recovering a shoot with no close-ups

You return from a shoot with only wide masters. The edit needs reaction shots.

1. Assess what exists: can any wide be reframed as a medium without losing resolution?
2. Identify whether any usable coverage exists from a second setup.
3. If not, plan a pickup shoot for reaction shots only, scheduled around the same costume and light.
4. Design the edit to work without reactions: use sound, inserts, or hold on the wide for effect.
5. Record the lesson in the shot list template for next time.

> **What to carry forward**
> When coverage fails, either shoot pickups or redesign the edit - never stretch a wide until it breaks.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Why is pre-production considered the most important stage of production?

15 marks

1. Define pre-production activities: script, schedule, permissions, crew, kit.
2. Explain cost logic: mistakes are cheapest to fix before shooting.
3. Give concrete failure examples caused by missing preparation.
4. Acknowledge that some discovery happens on set, and that preparation is what makes room for it.
5. Conclude that production executes decisions, so decisions must exist first.

Q2. Describe the three layers of a radio scene and explain their functions.

10 marks

1. Speech establishes action and character.
2. Effects establish place and movement.
3. Music or silence establishes emotional register and marks transitions.
4. Explain the need for acoustic bridges between locations.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Pre-production. Planning stage covering script, schedule, budget, crew, permissions and equipment.

Shot list. A prepared list of every shot required, used to shoot efficiently and completely.

Running order. The planned sequence and timing of items in a programme.

Actuality. Recorded speech or ambient sound from the real situation, used as evidence.

Room tone. The ambient sound of a location, recorded to smooth edits.

Package. A complete broadcast item combining links, actuality and effects.

Bed. Music or ambience played under speech, usually at reduced level.

Rough cut. A first assembly of edited material establishing structure.

Export. The final encoding of a programme into a deliverable file format.

Continuity. Consistency of props, costume and action between takes and scenes.

Consent. Permission from a contributor to be recorded and broadcast.

Pickup. An additional shoot to capture material missed in the main production.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Plan

The chain.

- Write a one-page production plan.
- Build a shot list or running order.
- Confirm permissions in writing.

Week 2 - Sound

Recording cleanly.

- Record dialogue close with headphones.
- Capture room tone at every setup.
- Build a three-layer radio scene.

Week 3 - Shoot

Coverage.

- Shoot master plus singles.
- Log every take on set.
- Shoot cutaways and inserts.

Week 4 - Post

Delivery.

- Assemble and cut to time.
- Balance levels and check on headphones.
- Export at the required settings and screen it.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any radio production handbook covering packages, actuality and levels.
- A film production text on shot lists, coverage and continuity.
- Your department's equipment manual and safety policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is a lavalier microphone usually better than a camera microphone?

Answer: It sits close to the speaker, capturing clearer dialogue and rejecting more room noise.

2. What coverage should you shoot for each scene?

Answer: A wide master, mediums, close-ups and cutaways, so the edit has choices.

3. What is wild track?

Answer: Audio recorded separately from picture, such as room tone or effects, used to build the soundtrack.

4. Why export and test on a phone?

Answer: Most viewers watch on mobile, and phone playback reveals level, framing and legibility problems.

5. Name two documentary ethics requirements.

Answer: Informed consent from contributors and accurate representation; release forms and protection of vulnerable subjects also apply.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write a one-page production proposal.
- [ ] Script a three-minute radio piece and a three-minute screen scene.
- [ ] Shoot coverage for one scene with logged takes.
- [ ] Record clean dialogue and room tone.
- [ ] Edit a rough cut and a fine cut.
- [ ] Mix audio and check levels on headphones and phone speaker.
- [ ] Export and screen it for feedback.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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